

12/5/25

Good evening. My name is Monica Strauser, and I am here tonight to express my continued opposition to raising taxes to fund the municipal expansion project.

Over the last few weeks, I have spoken with many of my neighbors, and it has become clear that most residents are **only just now learning** that this project exists. Because of that, on December 1st, I started a petition titled *“No New Taxes – Stop Municipal Expansion.”*

In just **two days**, that petition reached **300 signatures** and continues to grow.

That alone should signal to the Board that the public is **not on board** with the direction this project is heading.

Premature Taxation

I remain concerned about the proposed municipal building and cost to the residents. I am extremely disappointed that the Board is on the path to raise taxes for a building that has **not been approved**, whose final design is **not decided**, and whose community need has **not been demonstrated**.

At the November 5th meeting, the Board stated that the tax increase was necessary to “start ramping up” to pay for a future building. But you also insisted, repeatedly, that approving architectural work does *not* mean the expansion is approved.

You cannot have it both ways.

If the project is “not approved,” then **taxpayers should not be charged for it**.

It is **premature** and frankly **irresponsible**.

Lack of Community Outreach

I also want to express my disappointment at the Board’s lack of outreach on this issue.

While the Board has been discussing this project “for quite a while”, **residents have not**.

The larger community was not part of those conversations, and now we are suddenly being told that taxes must increase to support a project we barely understand.

One open house and a handful of emails are **not enough** for a capital project of this magnitude.

In my former township, East Fallowfield, the township used:

- weekly email updates

- quarterly or biannual mailed (USPS) newsletters
- e-mailed surveys
- and multiple public forums

Here, the Board has not meaningfully solicited input.

Residents are being asked to fund a multimillion-dollar expansion, but **we were never meaningfully brought into the process.**

Concerning Spending Trends

Further, I am deeply uncomfortable with how fast the cost of township government has increased.

In 2016, Kennett Township's millage rate was **0.2000**.

The 2026 budget proposes a millage of **3.7 mills**.

That is an increase of **1,750% in just nine years**.

This is not sustainable.

Residents are not a blank check.

It is also disingenuous to suggest that this year's tax increase is "reasonable" because it is below the Social Security COLA. We all know this is only the **first step** of a planned multi-year increase of **6–8 tenths of a mill**, which is roughly **a 20% tax increase**.

Let's be honest about what this is:

A long-term, structural expansion of government spending. Residents deserve full transparency.

Closing

The Board needs to answer; What **new** services will we get by having our taxes raised 20%? How do residents benefit from this plan? Residents need to feel the Board is listening to us — not simply preparing to grant whatever the employees of the township are asking for.

The number one priority for the Board of Supervisors should be to meet the needs expressed by the community and to deliver value for our tax dollars. I support the police, but that does not mean I support giving them a blank check. It's valid that we are running out of space, but that is not a need expressed by the community. These proposed tax increases place a burden on the citizens of our township with no appreciable benefit.

Right now, many of us do **not** feel heard.

The petition signatures, the growing community discussions, and the concerns voiced tonight show that residents want:

- **No new taxes for unapproved projects**
- **A halt to municipal expansion planning until the community is fully informed**
- **Meaningful outreach; including surveys, mailers, and transparent communication**
- **A fiscally conservative approach to township growth**

We want to be partners in shaping the future of our township - not just the people who get the bill.

Thank you.